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Baby Walkers: What the Research Says

And how to support walking instead · Ages 0–2

Walking is a skill babies build from the floor up: rolling, sitting, crawling, pulling up, cruising, then walking. Walkers skip those steps and add risk.

What the research found

- Over 230,000 children under 15 months in the US were treated for walker-related injuries between 1990 and 2014, most from falls down stairs (Sims et al., 2018).
- The American Academy of Pediatrics has called for a ban on the manufacture and sale of baby walkers.
- Babies who used walkers sat, crawled and walked later than babies who didn't, in a UK study (Garrett et al., 2002).

Support walking instead

- 0–6 months: daily tummy time on a firm mat, toys just out of reach.
- 6–9 months: lots of floor time to roll, sit and crawl.
- 9–12 months: a sturdy low table or sofa to pull up and cruise.
- 12+ months: a heavy, stable push toy; barefoot on safe floors.

Safety at home

- Safety gates at the top and bottom of stairs
- Secure heavy furniture to the wall
- Keep hot drinks and pan handles out of reach

Normal range

Most babies walk between 9 and 18 months. If your child isn't walking by about 18 months, talk to your paediatrician.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Sims, A., et al. (2018). Baby walker-related injuries in the United States. Pediatrics, 142(4).
Garrett, M., McElroy, A. M., & Staines, A. (2002). Locomotor milestones and babywalkers: cross sectional study. BMJ, 324, 1494.

General information, not medical advice.